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Culture (OWC): [Shona \(FS05\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

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Place Coverage: Zaka, Masvingo, Zimbabwe

Section Title(S): THE BRIDE IS ABDUCTED (KUTIZISA)

The somewhat broader term *mwana womukati*, “the child from within” becomes clear in this context. In a way, the child also belongs to Farai’s circle, his sister’s uterus is the link that establishes the contact. Farai’s sister was the first to open Farai’s circle from the inside: the *muzukuru*, a stranger, opens it still further from the outside and thus, himself, becomes a member of an alien circle.

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When Farai fell in love with Tendai he first sent his niece to make contact. After that, Farai’s newphew (*muzukuru*) – let us call him Muzhara – became his regular messenger, carrying all those messages that are nowadays conveyed by letter. Tendai treats Muzhara as kindly as she would treat Farai, thus establishing a so-called joking relationship with him. If Farai dies, Muzhara can make Tendai his wife; because of the joking relationship the two know each other well without having had sexual relations.

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As soon as Tendai accepts him, Farai informs his *muzukuru*, Muzhara, who then tells his own mother. She keeps her parents informed who, in this way, first come to hear about their son's love. Thus, the initial unofficial announcement is made by the person who symbolizes the opening of the circle, the new love representing another such opening.

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The *muzukuru* also plays a part in connection with the cattle which is paid as bride-price: it goes first to him and then to Farai's parents. Muzhara here represents his mother, for it is she who provides the *fuma* which enables Farai to marry. In this capacity, Muzhara ranks higher than Farai, his uncle.

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Why must Farai's sister (Muzhara's mother) be represented symbolically? The Karanga say that an alien circle is connected with the bride-price, and Muzhara's mother cannot represent that circle herself because she is related by blood to Farai. The *muzukuru* is ideally suited for this role for he belongs to another circle, yet, via the uterus which bore him, he is closely connected with Farai's circle.

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This close connection also explains a number of other things. When the cattle-kraal is inspected (*kuona danga*, cf p. 164) it is a *muzukuru* who shows the cattle to the father-in-law. The *muzukuru* must also be present at other ceremonies such as, for example, the *gusha* (cf p. 172). His mother need not necessarily attend these rituals, but his own presence is important. He is the symbolic representative of the opening of the circle as presented in these rituals.

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The day before the abduction Muzhara walks through Tendai's village  176 as a sign that the abduction will take place as arranged. During the night of the abduction Muzhara is the most important man too because he represents his uncle, Tendai's future husband who is not permitted to be present himself. That night one says of the *muzukuru* "he carries Tendai", i.e. he takes her away from home. He is also the one who carries Tendai on his back for the last part of the way.

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*755 Prospect Street
New Haven, CT 06511*

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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